

A table of important Linux configuration files and their purpose.

User & Authentication

Configuration File	Purpose
<code>/etc/passwd</code>	Stores user account information (username, UID, home dir, shell)
<code>/etc/shadow</code>	Stores encrypted user passwords
<code>/etc/group</code>	Defines system groups
<code>/etc/gshadow</code>	Secure group password file
<code>/etc/login.defs</code>	User account policies (UID range, password aging rules)

Sudo & Privileges

Configuration File	Purpose
<code>/etc/sudoers</code>	Defines who can run sudo and what commands
<code>/etc/sudoers.d</code>	Additional sudo configuration files

Network Configuration

Configuration File	Purpose
<code>/etc/hosts</code>	Static hostname-to-IP mappings
<code>/etc/resolv.conf</code>	DNS server configuration

<code>/etc/hostname</code>	System hostname
<code>/etc/sysconfig/network</code> (RHEL-based)	Network settings (older systems)
<code>/etc/netplan/*.yaml</code> (Ubuntu)	Network configuration (newer Ubuntu)



File System & Mounting

Configuration File	Purpose
<code>/etc/fstab</code>	Defines filesystems to mount at boot
<code>/etc/mtab</code>	Shows currently mounted filesystems
<code>/etc/exports</code>	NFS shared directories configuration



Boot & Kernel

Configuration File	Purpose
<code>/etc/default/grub</code>	GRUB bootloader settings
<code>/boot/grub2/grub.cfg</code>	Generated GRUB configuration
<code>/etc/sysctl.conf</code>	Kernel parameter configuration
<code>/proc/sys/</code>	Runtime kernel parameters



System & Services (systemd)

Configuration File	Purpose
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<code>/etc/systemd/system</code> <code>/</code>	Custom systemd service files
<code>/usr/lib/systemd/system/</code>	Default service unit files
<code>/etc/rc.local</code>	Startup commands (legacy systems)

Security & Access

Configuration File	Purpose
<code>/etc/ssh/sshd_config</code>	SSH server configuration
<code>/etc/pam.d/</code>	PAM authentication configuration
<code>/etc/selinux/config</code>	SELinux mode configuration
<code>/etc/security/limits.conf</code>	User resource limits

Cron & Scheduling

Configuration File	Purpose
<code>/etc/crontab</code>	System-wide cron jobs
<code>/etc/cron.d/</code>	Additional cron job configs
<code>/var/spool/cron/</code>	User-specific cron jobs

Package Management

RHEL / CentOS / Rocky

Configuration File	Purpose
<code>/etc/yum.conf</code>	Yum configuration
<code>/etc/yum.repos.d/</code>	Repository definitions

Ubuntu / Debian

Configuration File	Purpose
<code>/etc/apt/sources.list</code>	APT repository list
<code>/etc/apt/sources.list.d/</code>	Additional repository configs



Shell & Environment

Configuration File	Purpose
<code>/etc/profile</code>	System-wide login shell config
<code>/etc/bashrc</code> or <code>/etc/bash.bashrc</code>	System-wide bash config
<code>~/.bashrc</code>	User interactive shell config
<code>~/.bash_profile</code>	User login shell config
<code>/etc/environment</code>	Global environment variables



Logging

Configuration File	Purpose
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`/etc/rsyslog.conf` System logging configuration

`/etc/logrotate.conf` Log rotation settings

`/var/log/` Log file directory

Most Important for DevOps / Admin Interviews

If you remember these 10, you're safe:

- `/etc/passwd`
 - `/etc/shadow`
 - `/etc/group`
 - `/etc/fstab`
 - `/etc/hosts`
 - `/etc/resolv.conf`
 - `/etc/ssh/sshd_config`
 - `/etc/sudoers`
 - `/etc/crontab`
 - `/etc/sysctl.conf`
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